the night patrols confirming there was no contact with the Chinese south of the river. Across the river, the fires continued to flicker on the hillsides.

With just a hint of grey towards the east, at 5.14 a.m., a series of flashes were seen on the Thagla slopes, the sound of the mortars carrying through a few seconds later. Rikh wrote: ‘The enemy commenced heavy shelling of all four company localities simultaneously. The shelling was from 82-mm mortars deployed on the forward slopes of the Thagla, and from heavy 120-mm mortars deployed behind the Thagla feature. The enemy shelling was intense and continued for about an hour. We had no weapon to counter the enemy mortars.’ The initial salvos ranged onto their targets, and gradually the intensity increased. Some of the cast iron bombs hit the trees, adding yet another frightening dimension to the deafening explosions that had engulfed the Rajput positions. The noise and the unrelenting shelling succeeded in driving the troops out of the open defences into the makeshift bunkers. The men huddled together, their weapons ready, as they peered out of the firing bays towards the front. They were completely unaware of the impending attack that was building up towards their rear.

The initial casualties all occurred in the first few minutes, as splinters hit some men before they could get under cover. At Battalion HQ at Bridge 4, the moment the Chinese opened up, Captain Gurucharan Bhatia had sprinted across to the mortar platoon while Captain Mahabir Mangat raced off to the communications bunker. Bhatia immediately attempted to engage the Chinese with the battalion’s 3-inch mortars, firing at maximum range. However, the rounds landed nearly 300 metres short of the Chinese positions.

The Chinese had clearly marked out the battalion’s signal bunker. Having forced the troops to take cover, a couple of 75-mm RCLs (recoilless guns) started firing from across the river. These direct firing weapons opened up on the communication hub of the battalion. The last message from the bunker had been transmitted some fifteen minutes after the first mortar salvos had been fired. The direct hits completely destroyed the signal bunker, killing all the men inside, including the gallant Mangat.

The Chinese, having zeroed in on Bhatia’s mortar position, now intensified their fire, and within minutes all the 2 Rajput 3-inch mortars were knocked out. At Log Bridge, disaster struck as the company commander Lieutenant Subash Chander was killed just when the Chinese bombardment was lifting; one of the last few mortar shells hit the